The resentment is not limited to issues of strategy but to the Congress's style of functioning as well. For example, several leaders attribute Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar's departure from the bloc in January 2024 to the Congress's refusal to name him—one of the alliance's key architects—as convenor. Omar emphasises the need for sustained engagement within the bloc, criticising the sporadic, election-centric strategy. "Our existence can't just be about six months before Parliament election. It has to be something more," he stated, advocating a structured framework of regular interactions. The bloc's leaders have not met formally since June 2024.

The Congress Game Plan

The varying dynamics across states highlight the challenges Congress faces as both a national party and an INDIA bloc member. In states where it partners with regional heavyweights, the party risks losing its organisational base. Over the next two years, seven states—Delhi and Bihar this year, followed by Assam, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala in 2026—will head to the polls. Barring Tamil Nadu, where it enjoys a stable alliance with the DMK, the Congress will be contesting primarily on its own strength in the other states. "Alliances, if they happen, will be decided in consultation with local leaders and based on an assessment of the local situation. Our focus is on strengthening the party core rather than reacting to external commentary," says a Congress Working Committee (CWC) member.

In Bihar, for instance, which goes to the polls later this year, Congress leaders argue that decades of alliance with the RJD have left them dependent on their regional partner. In the 2024 general election, the Congress won three out of the nine seats it contested in Bihar, while the RJD managed only four out of 23 seats. This underperformance has not only strained RJD-Congress ties but also fuelled speculation that Lalu's support for Mamata's INDIA leadership bid is to strengthen his bargaining chip ahead of the Bihar polls. Similarly, Pawar's stand in favour of Mamata is being seen as an effort to stay relevant amid his NCP's existential crisis. By positioning himself as a kingmaker in the bloc, Pawar hopes to retain his influence.

CONGRESS ROADMAP

- By targeting Kejriwal/AAP, Congress signals intent to reclaim political ground from allies in states where it has lost relevance
- Top priority are strengthening organisation, the seven states heading for polls in 2025-26
- Major party restructuring planned, leveraging the period between the Delhi assembly election next month, and the Bihar polls later this year

Recognising the urgent need for change, Congress president Kharge has outlined a roadmap for organisational restructuring. At a recent CWC meeting, he emphasised the importance of discipline and grassroots engagement. "Tough decisions will be made," he said, signalling an impending overhaul of the party's structure from the grassroots to the top leadership. Insiders suggest that these changes will not merely involve personnel but will redefine the roles, responsibilities and powers of party positions. Congress leaders are banking on the period between the Delhi elections in February and the Bihar polls later this year to implement these reforms.

The problem with the Congress is that planning often proves far easier than execution. Despite Kharge's stern warnings about maintaining discipline, infighting continues to afflict the party across states such as Karnataka, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab and Kerala. The Congress high command has attempted to channel the energies of senior leaders by assigning them responsibilities in other states. For instance, former Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot, ex-Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and Kerala veteran Ramesh Chennithala were tasked with election duties during the recent assembly polls. "Don't be surprised if the final remnants of 'Camp Ahmed Patel' [the late all-powerful political secretary of Sonia Gandhi] fade into the sunset between March and October this year," remarks a Congress MP.

Such statements have been made in private earlier too. The Congress had pledged an organisational overhaul during its Udaipur Chintan Shivir in 2022 and reiterated these commitments at the Raipur plenary in 2023. While some reforms, like the establishment of political taskforces and the initiation of training programmes for workers were implemented, they have been superficial. Structural changes to empower grassroots leaders or improve decision-making processes were largely ignored, leaving the party vulnerable to infighting and inefficiency.

As for the INDIA bloc, its unity has always been tenuous, built on a shared antipathy for the BJP rather than ideological alignment. As the Congress recalibrates strategy, this fragility is becoming increasingly apparent. For the bloc to remain viable, the Congress must strike a delicate balance. Its allies want a more inclusive leadership style and equitable seat-sharing arrangements. Failure to address these concerns could lead to fragmentation, jeopardising Opposition prospects in 2025 and beyond. ■

The allies are frustrated over Rahul's fixation on issues like crony capitalism, as it is divorced from the everyday concerns of the people